needed $5.5 billion of foreign aid to meet its $24 billion third-plan goals. That summer, the India aid consortium pledged $2 billion for the first two years, including $1 billion from the US. In addition, the administration committed $1.3 billion in food assistance for India.[166]

The Kennedy administration also started negotiations to supply India with nuclear reactors. While officials dismissed the idea of helping India develop nuclear weapons, as David Engerman has noted, China's nuclear program contributed to the American desire to facilitate an Indian civilian nuclear one. The Atomic Energy Commission backed the Tarapur Atomic Power Station project partly on the grounds that it could be "a major counterweight to Red Chinese atomic energy developments." John Kenneth Galbraith, ambassador to India, in turn, would see it as a useful "counter" to a prospective Chinese nuclear test.[167]

On aid and beyond, Nehru was pleased with the new administration's approach. He appreciated Kennedy's efforts to work toward aid programs on a long-term basis.[168] Johnson's assertion in Delhi that "military force alone can never be a permanent bulwark against Communist activities" in Asia was also music to Nehru's ears.[169] Moreover, Kennedy had publicly said he would make a special effort to reach out to nonaligned countries. Dutt believed he would even be willing to sort out disagreements with Moscow. And Nehru thought the administration's attitude on the issues of Angola, Congo, and Laos showed a "marked change" in the foreign policy realm.[170] India would indeed work with the US on the latter two issues.[171]

Indian officials also tried to handle differences carefully. India's reaction to the Bay of Pigs invasion in spring 1961, for example, was cautious.[172] Initially, Nehru called the situation "distressing," but refused further comment until he had more details. His government ensured that the issue was not debated in parliament, despite Communist Party demands. As pressure built on Nehru, he did make a statement in parliament that made clear his disapproval of US actions. Just a few days later, however, he expressed faith in Kennedy's assurances and played down his previous criticism.[173]

Quid Pro Quo?

Kennedy administration officials hoped that Nehru would stay on that path, but developments in fall 1961 would take a bit of the sheen off the Indian